

can only grow both in numbers as well as skills. Multiplexes are a major contributor to employment generation as they employ people with diverse skill sets.

As someone who has been actively associated with the cinema industry for over three decades, and the multiplex revolution over the past 25 years, I have witnessed how the world of entertainment has evolved, from a traditional mass entertainment medium to a dynamic, multifaceted consumer retail experience. While the Covid-19 lockdowns forced cinema producers to take the OTT (over-the-top) route, changing viewer habits, and creating a pan-India market for regional movies like *Kantara*, it also created a demand for home delivery of theatre food.

Post-Covid, the OTT experience has also given producers and studios the confidence to explore diverse creative approaches, transcending languages, local and regional preferences giving audiences a full screen experience across genres. I expect this trend to grow exponentially with more multiplexes coming up to cater to this consumer demand.

For Indians, a visit to the cinema is not just about watching movies. It is a celebratory event, to be shared with family, friends, colleagues, and acquaintances. In spite of its massive population and being among the world's biggest movie-making industries, India is still hugely under screened.

A 2019 report by Ficci-EY had pegged our screen count at eight per million population, way behind 125 screens per million in the US and 80 in the UK. Multiplexes, as a consequence of mall expansion beyond metros to Tier I, II and III cities will provide a platform for a diverse range of movies

to thrill audiences on a big screen.

Cinemas will no longer be simply venues for watching films. Just as digital has taken over content creation and delivery, the sound and light experience that was cinema will now evolve into social and interactive spaces with the architecture designed to enhance the overall experience—such as dedicated selfie spaces adorned with static art. Youngsters, in particular, find these spaces irresistible, turning their cinema outings into social media-worthy events.

With the rapid progress of Generative AI, cinemas will continue to go beyond mainstream blockbusters and diversify their content to

development model. On the other hand, with increased focus on green energy and activism for reduced greenhouse gas emissions, the nation is steering towards reducing its carbon footprint. In an era marked by climate emergencies and pandemics, building resilience will become a key aspect of India's agenda for safeguarding communities and sustaining progress.

With the 3D effect of demographics, digital public infrastructure and a dynamic creative start-up ecosystem, India's five-year agenda for 2029 must have a holistic approach for nation building, encompassing economic, social, environmental, and geopo-

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TODAY, THE INDIAN CONSUMER IS EARNING WELL AND SPENDING WELL. WITH INCREASING PER CAPITA INCOME, THEIR SPENDING CAPABILITY HAS ALSO GROWN

include independent and foreign language films. For instance, filmmakers could be integrating AI-based Indian language translators like Bhashini, to create 'Indian' multilingual films that transcend regional boundaries, thus, opening up larger geographies, markets, and a diverse consumer base.

If the Covid-19 paradigm was 'Aatmanirbhar Bharat' (self-reliant India), the next steps towards a sustainable and inclusive future will be on the path of 'Viksit Bharat' (developed India). On the one hand, with better hygiene, nutrition and healthcare, the nation is making rapid strides towards a grassroots

political considerations. And just as society influences films, cinemas too play a vital role in influencing society. With effective implementation, adaptability, and resilience to evolving circumstances, and a collaborative approach between the government, private sector, and civil society, I believe the coming decade holds the potential for a great leap forward in shaping the destiny of one of the world's largest, most dynamic and youthful nations. **BT**

The author is Managing Director of PVR Inox. Views are personal